



GDD 16

Crossroads

Stop, think, choose well

The decisions-and-consequences game for ages 9-12, built to the mechanic-embodiment standard, and the branching-dilemma flagship. Children pause, see their options, weigh the "then what?", and choose by their values, through real friendship and peer crossroads. Seven mechanics, 36 real-choice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Stop, think, choose well.

Crossroads is the decision-making game, and the branching-dilemma flagship of the whole app. It teaches a clear routine, stop and think, see your options, weigh the consequences, check your values, then choose and own it, applied to the friendship, peer and feelings crossroads that fill a pre-teen's day. It builds on Friend or Frenemy (g09) and Boundary Bot (g15), turning their lessons into a reusable way to decide. New v2 build to the standard.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g16 · crossroads (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 3 · ages 9-12 · light canvas · solo or peer
Thread / topics	D · Relationships · UNESCO 1.1, 1.2, 1.4, 5.1, 5.2, 5.3, 7.1
Prerequisite / builds on	g15 (Boundary Bot) · builds on g09 (Friend or Frenemy)
Gating	Core
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS the branching-dilemma flagship.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

36

real-choice moves

10

myths busted

0%

binary taps

A day full of choices.

From the Chapter 3 personas. Pre-teens make dozens of consequential choices a day, often alone, this gives them a routine to make them well.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Aarav, 12 (peer-driven, impulsive)	To pause and think before reacting to pressure.	branch + role-play : stop-and-think; "let me think".
Diya, 11	To navigate friend dilemmas without losing herself.	branch : friendship crossroads.
Asha, 24 (peer educator)	To model honest, caring decision support.	role-play + branch : advise & support.
Rohit (parent)	A kid who'll come ask for advice on big calls.	branch + reflect : ask a trusted adult.
Every child	A reusable routine for any choice.	build + reflect : the decision steps.

Why this works (the evidence). Good decision-making is teachable as a routine: stop and think (pause/breathe), see several options (not black-and-white), ask "what might happen if I choose this?" for good and bad outcomes, then decide by your values and goals, not impulse or pressure. Practising on real dilemmas, and owning the results, is how judgement grows.

Seven moves, one routine.

The rework's heart: decision-making arrives through seven actions, and this is the game where **branch** rightly leads, every dilemma is a real choice with consequences and a debrief. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE CHILD DOES	EMBODIES	N
branch (dilemma) signature	Decides a real crossroads, sees the consequence, gets a debrief.	The whole decision routine.	29
reflect	Considers values, the "then what?", and what they'd be proud of.	Values; foresight; metacognition.	26
strike-rewrite	Erases a decision myth ("decide fast", "everyone's doing it").	Conceptual change.	10
role-play (voice)	Says "let me think", the values line, the honest answer.	Pausing; assertion; integrity.	7
sort	Sorts real options vs false 'only-two'; ahead vs only-now.	Options & foresight.	7
build	Builds the stop-think routine / pros-and-cons check.	The reusable framework.	3
match	Pairs choice to likely consequence; value to action.	Cause & effect.	2

36 of 84 moments are branch or role-play, decisions are made by deciding. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it fun?

Crossroads plays like a choose-your-path adventure with real stakes: you stand at a fork, weigh it, pick, and watch the ripple, then see what a different path would have done. The dilemmas are drawn straight from pre-teen life (the dare, the cover-up, the left-out kid, the heat-of-the-moment text), and the "what would you do?" pull is exactly the autonomy the strategy says makes play feel like play, not school.

Is it teaching?

Yes, a transferable decision-making routine: pause, generate options, weigh consequences (short and long term), decide by values, and own the outcome, plus the specific friendship and peer judgement calls of this age.

The belief it moves. From "decide fast; it's their way or no friends; only right-now matters; everyone's doing it so it's fine; a bad call means I'm bad" → "pause and think, there's usually a third option, weigh the 'then what?', decide by my values, and own and learn from my choices."

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across six steps of the decision routine, drawn from real pre-teen crossroads. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
Stop and think	12	branch, role-play, build	Pause before acting; don't decide in the heat; "let me think".
See your options	12	branch, sort, reflect	More than two choices; third paths; brainstorming; waiting.
Weigh the consequences	16	branch, match, sort	"Then what?"; short vs long term; pros/cons; who's affected.
Decide by your values	14	reflect, branch, strike-rewrite	Values as compass; popular isn't always right; integrity unwatched.
Friendship crossroads	16	branch, role-play, sort	Loyalty vs right; cover-ups; pick-a-side; include vs exclude.
Owning your choice	14	branch, reflect, build	Take responsibility; learn from a bad call; change course; ask advice.

A branch scenario (weigh the consequences), verbatim.

hook: "You could copy a friend's homework to save time tonight."
 option A "Think ahead: you'd learn nothing and could get caught" -> do your own / ask for help [best]
 option B "Copy without thinking ahead" -> 'then what?' shows copying costs more than it saves
 debrief: "Ask 'then what?', the short win can cost more later."

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 16 Crossroads — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game erases.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
The faster you decide, the better.	A short pause to think leads to better choices.	Stop and think.
It's always their way or no friends.	Most situations have several options, not two.	Options thinking.
Only how I feel right now matters.	Good choices weigh the future too.	Long-term thinking.
If everyone's doing it, it's right.	Popular and right aren't the same; decide for yourself.	Values vs conformity.
Real friends cover for you no matter what.	Real friends care for your wellbeing, not just your wishes.	Loyalty vs right.
A bad decision means I'm bad or stupid.	Everyone makes some bad calls; what matters is learning.	Growth mindset.
The right choice only counts if people notice.	The right choice matters even unwatched.	Integrity.
Asking for time looks indecisive.	Taking time to think is a sign of a careful decider.	Stop and think.

The micro-loop.

1. **Hook.** Lensy: "you're at a crossroads, which way?".
2. **Play.** A dilemma (branch), or a step of the routine (options, consequences, values), rotated.
3. **Ripple.** The choice plays out, then a "what the other path would've done" debrief; no buzzer.
4. **UN → RE moment.** On a myth, UN erases it and RE writes the truth ("decide fast" → "pause and think").
5. **Apply.** Build the decision routine, say the "let me think" line, or weigh a pros/cons.
6. **Sticker.** The Crossroads compass badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surface: the **branching dilemma card**, decide, see the ripple, compare paths, the reusable engine that later relationship/ethics nodes (Stand Up, Mutual, Crossroads-style adult dilemmas) all draw on.

Decide, don't dictate.

- **Register.** Ages 9-12, near-peer and respectful; Lensy poses the fork, the child decides, never a moral handed down.
- **Real autonomy.** Dilemmas often have more than one defensible move; the game backs the child's reasoning and debriefs gently.
- **Safe to be wrong.** A weaker choice plays out as a learnable consequence, never a buzzer; "you can change course" is built in.
- **Values, not preaching.** The game helps the child find their own values rather than imposing a verdict.
- **Route to support.** Big or risky calls route to "ask a trusted adult"; safety dilemmas link to Boundary Bot (g15) and Safety Squad (g08).
- **Access.** Audio-first, offline; India-grounded crossroads; pairs with Friend or Frenemy (g09).

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. crossroads** — `node.game === GameDone key === registry id` (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema**. Each scenario carries type + typed payload, with the **branch** renderer (options + consequence + outcome + debrief) doing the heavy lifting, the shared template that powers every later dilemma node.
- **Scorecard-gated**. Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, branch at the 35% cap, 0% binary, 36 autonomy, 10 UN→RE, 5 personas, 100% completeness). Re-run `score_gdd.py` on any edit.
- **Reuse**. Crossroads' branch engine is the reference implementation for Stand Up (g27), Mutual (g31) and the adult dilemma games; build once, reuse widely.
- **Generated path**. Label/order/thread changes flow through the `xlsx` + `gen-path`, never hand-edited `path.ts`.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): decide not dictate; real autonomy (more than one good move); safe-to-be-wrong; help find values, don't preach; route big/risky calls to a trusted adult; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Decision-making is a teachable routine.** The evidence-based steps, stop and think, list several options, weigh "what might happen?" for good and bad outcomes, then decide by values and goals, are exactly the routine this game builds and rehearses.
- **Think ahead, beyond black-and-white.** Pre-teens benefit from being pushed past two options and toward the longer-term picture ("how will I feel tomorrow?"), which the branch debriefs and "see your options" category train directly.
- **Practice and ownership build judgement.** Working real dilemmas, weighing pros and cons, and owning the outcomes is how good judgement develops, so the game is dilemma-led and ends each on a learnable debrief.

Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 18 games now v2. Next in Chapter 3: Flip the Script (g17, challenging gender stereotypes).